

European Subordination and Burmese Realpolitik: Power Dynamics Across Cultures in the Mid-Eighteenth-Century Irrawaddy Valley

Conrad Compagna

Author manuscript • Submitted to Journal of Burma Studies.

Abstract

In the mid-eighteenth century, the collapse of the Toungoo dynasty produced a variety of successor states competing to establish local power bases and forge larger agglomerative polities after the image of the *ekaraja*, or universal monarch. Three European trading corporations entered into this conflict—the English East India Company, the French *Compagnie des Indes*, and the Ostend Company—each pursuing their own imperial ambitions within this wider struggle. Drawing on English, French, and Burmese sources, this article reconstructs the tangled warren of negotiation, coercion, and violence used on all sides to achieve strategic economic, political, and military objectives. The main finding presented by the paper is that power politics, although couched in culturally specific idioms and constrained (and enabled) by historically specific conditions, took place on a single playing field marked by shrewd wealth/power calculation on all sides. The paper argues against strong-form cultural relativism in the analysis of politics, pointing to underlying uniformities in goal-oriented, strategic behavior across cultural boundaries, despite large differences in worldviews and structural embedding.

Keywords

Burma/Myanmar, Konbaung dynasty, Toungoo collapse, Pegu (Hanthawaddy), Tavoy, English East India Company, French East India Company, Ostend Company, Indian Ocean intermediaries, cross-cultural diplomacy, realpolitik

In the mid-18th century, Burma became embroiled in a fast-changing, multi-sided conflict ensuing from the collapse of the Toungoo dynasty, which led to a struggle between two successor states—Pegu and Ava—and a host of lesser players, from exiled Toungoo princes to minor borderland city-states that had spun out from the orbit of the Toungoo court.¹ Three different European trading corporations were drawn into the struggle, who were themselves in the mid-18th century engaged in geopolitical competition in locales as far-flung as Senegal, Canada, and the Coromandel Coast of India.² These included the English East

¹ The vast majority of translated terms used are established Anglicized forms taken from the body of primary and secondary source literature the paper is based on. Any spellings without prevailing conventions are in the transliteration scheme defined in John Okell, *A Guide to the Romanization of Burmese* (London: Royal Asiatic Society of Great Britain and Ireland, 1971).

² Trevor Burnard, Emma Hart, and Marie Houlemmare, eds., *The Oxford Handbook of the Seven Years' War* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2024).

India Company (EIC), the French Compagnie des Indes, and the Habsburg-based Ostend Company, which was outlawed by treaty around the War of the Austrian Succession but continued to operate illicitly for several more decades.

French involvement with the Pegu court led to the EIC seizing and building a fort on the island of Negrais; over the next decade, the EIC engaged in negotiations with multiple rulers in a failed bid to obtain retroactive legitimacy for the annexation. All three companies were driven violently out of Burma: the Ostenders ambushed and slaughtered by the Pegu court; the French wiped out as part of Alaungpaya's campaign against Pegu, their remnants absorbed into the networks of labor control presided over by the Konbaung royal household; the English base destroyed in a devastating surprise attack, severing diplomatic relations for decades.

The only comprehensive archivally-grounded study of the embassies remains D.G.E. Hall's 'The Tragedy of Negrais' (1931), a long and empirically rich narrative firmly rooted in colonial interpretive frameworks. Hall's analysis privileges European actors—especially the British. When non-European actors do feature, no systematic effort is made to contextualize their actions, and their agency is described in stereotyped terms—Armenian and Portuguese

intermediaries, for example, are perfidious schemers; Burmese rulers despotic and irrational.³

The few modern studies of these embassies offer only partial coverage. Maung Htin Aung's *Anglo-Burmese Relations* and Dorothy Woodman's *The Making of Burma* are mostly focused on later diplomatic exchanges; their treatment of the mid-18th century is brief and largely reliant on a single published source.⁴ François Ternat reconstructs high-level deliberations in Versailles and

³ D. G. E. Hall, "The Tragedy of Negrais," *Journal of the Burma Research Society* 21, no. 3 (1931): 59–133. Specific language on intermediaries includes "crouching" Armenians and "clumsy intriguers"; Hall wrote that Alaungpaya did not like treaties because Burmese kings did not like being bound by "conditions they could not revoke at pleasure"; that he was "sublimely ignorant" of English power; his destruction of the Negrais settlement is psychologized as paranoia rather than a rational response to territorial encroachment.

⁴ Maung Htin Aung, *The Stricken Peacock: Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1752–1948* (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1965), 12–19; Dorothy Woodman, *The Making of Burma* (London: Cresset Press, 1962), 31–40; Alexander Dalrymple, *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1 (London: G. Biggs, 1793–97).

Pondicherry regarding the French presence in Pegu.⁵ Jacques Leider has published a famous piece of diplomatic correspondence from the period, a richly adorned letter sent by Alaungpaya to the English King George II, and provided up-to-date commentary on the context behind the sending of the letter and the cultural meanings embedded in the gesture.⁶

This paper constitutes the first modern English-language study spanning all three European trading corporations and their interactions with multiple regional courts. Its central contribution is to provide a thick micro-historical reconstruction of ubiquitous shrewd, ruthless realpolitik calculation in the quest for wealth and power on the part of both sets of actors.

The article proceeds in five parts: Part 1 presents the conceptual framework and literature review; Part 2 provides historical background on the

⁵ François Ternat, “Lettre d’or et canon. Diplomatie française et britannique auprès des cours birmanes pendant la guerre de Sept Ans,” in *Une diplomatie des lointains. La France face à la mondialisation des rivalités internationales, XVIIe–XVIIIe siècles*, eds. Éric Schnakenbourg and François Ternat (Rennes: Presses universitaires de Rennes, 2020), 335–60.

⁶ Jacques P. Leider, *King Alaungmintaya’s Golden Letter to King George II (7 May 1756): The Story of an Exceptional Manuscript and the Failure of a Diplomatic Overture* (Hannover: Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz Bibliothek, 2009).

Toungoo collapse before the period under study; Part 3 examines the city-state of Tavoy and its relationship to the EIC; Part 4 examines Pegu and its relationship to all three trading corporations under study; and Part 5 examines the Konbaung dynasty's quest for arms and military dominance over the Irrawaddy valley.

PART 1. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK AND LITERATURE REVIEW

Southeast Asian historiography has been heavily influenced by the cultural turn emerging from late twentieth-century anthropology, whose central premise is the questioning of the universal applicability of European categories to the study of non-European peoples and pasts.⁷ Perhaps the best exemplar of this is Clifford

⁷ Stanley Jeyaraja Tambiah, "The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia," *HAU: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 3, no. 3 (2013): 503–34; O. W. Wolters, *History, Culture, and Region in Southeast Asian Perspectives*, rev. ed. (Ithaca, NY: Southeast Asia Program Publications, Cornell University, 1999); Edmund R. Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma: A Study of Kachin Social Structure* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press for the London School of Economics and Political Science, 1954); Lucien M. Hanks, "Merit and Power in the Thai Social Order," *American Anthropologist* 64, no. 6 (December 1962): 1247–61; Benedict R. O'G. Anderson, "The Idea of Power in Javanese Culture," in *Culture and Politics in Indonesia* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1972), 1–70.

Geertz, who, in his famous work *Negara: The Theatre State in Nineteenth-Century Bali*, argued against an Enlightenment-derived concept of uniform human nature with culture as its outward manifestation, claiming that in nineteenth-century Bali, pomp served power, not the other way around.⁸

This paper puts forward a different vision of Southeast Asian politics, placing it alongside comparative historical sociology that has repeatedly surfaced analogous patterns in state formation across the early modern world, from France to Japan.⁹ Such studies tend to be macro-structural, identifying broad patterns in

⁸ Clifford Geertz, *Negara: The Theatre State in Nineteenth-Century Bali*

(Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980).

⁹ Victor B. Lieberman, *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, c. 800–1830, vol. 1: Integration on the Mainland* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003); Victor B. Lieberman, *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, c. 800–1830, vol. 2: Mainland Mirrors: Europe, Japan, China, South Asia, and the Islands* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009); Jack A. Goldstone, *Revolution and Rebellion in the Early Modern World: Population Change and State Breakdown in England, France, Turkey, and China, 1600–1850* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1991); Theda Skocpol, *States and Social Revolutions: A Comparative Analysis of France, Russia, and China* (Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press, 1979).

the accumulation of resources and in the concentration of power over time. Rarely do they narrow down to the interpersonal level, analyzing the individual words and deeds through which state building efforts were actualized.

The paper does not dismiss the role of culture,¹⁰ nor does it dismiss the unique structural conditions in which Southeast Asian statecraft emerged.¹¹

¹⁰ Michael W. Charney, *Powerful Learning: Buddhist Literati and the Throne in Burma's Last Dynasty, 1752–1885* (Ann Arbor: Centers for South and Southeast Asian Studies, University of Michigan, 2006); Alexey Kirichenko, “From Ava to Mandalay: Toward Charting the Development of Burmese Yazawin Traditions,” *Journal of Burma Studies* 13, no. 1 (2009): 1–75; Jacques P. Leider, “Buddhist Diplomacy: Confrontation and Political Rhetoric in the Exchange of Letters between King Alaungmintaya and King Banya Dala of Pegu (1755–56),” in *Buddhist Dynamics in Premodern and Early Modern Southeast Asia*, ed. D. Christian Lammerts (Singapore: ISEAS Publishing, 2015), 373–416. For an overview of the way this tightly linked relationship between political order and Buddhist thought changed during the 19th century, see Aurore Candier, “Convergences conceptuelles en Birmanie : la transition du xix^e siècle,” *Moussons*, no. 16 (2010): 81–101.

¹¹ James C. Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009); Michael W.

Culture and structure governed the context in which politics was conducted, provided the tools through which rulers could achieve their goals, set out behavioral constraints and provided a conceptual repertoire for self-understanding.

But an inventory of the actual goals themselves—the defeat and ruination of rivals, the construction of imperial domains, the procurement of resources and weapons; and of the methods used in the pursuit of those goals—the construction of fragile, fast-changing alliances, simultaneous outward cooperation and veiled conflict, broken oaths, imprisonments, deception, intimidation, double-crossing, threats, and violence, both on an individuated and mass scale—suggests the presence of a shared underlying reality in what constituted power and what kinds of methods were successful in securing it.

This is not to imply that Burmese kings actively conceptualized their actions in terms derived from European political theory. Rather, such theories themselves, as crystallized in works like Machiavelli's *The Prince*, are not unique to Europe at all. Millennia before the Renaissance, one finds evidence of similarly instrumental political thought, in which politics is treated as an arena of practical

Charney, *Southeast Asian Warfare, 1300–1900* (Leiden & Boston: Brill, 2004); Michael Aung-Thwin and Maitrii Aung-Thwin, *A History of Myanmar Since Ancient Times: Traditions and Transformations* (London: Reaktion Books, 2012).

action, and actions are judged by their usefulness, rather than their intrinsic moral goodness—for example, Kautilya’s *Arthashastra*, a text produced by the chief vizier of Chandragupta Maurya, ruler of the Maurya Empire in ancient India, who advocated the pragmatic pursuit of state interests through short-term alliances, the use of deception, coercion, and violence as strategic instruments, and spying and information control targeted both at domestic and external opponents.¹² Such texts, which often surface in times of intractable interstate conflict, as in Warring States China,¹³ represent a shared grammar of power politics, independently voiced in different times and places by individuals who have considered the calculus, shorn of idealism, of how to take and maintain power.

PART 2. HISTORICAL BACKGROUND: TOUNGOO COLLAPSE

The Toungoo dynasty was the central political fact across much of mainland Southeast Asia from the 15th to 18th centuries, at times occupying a sprawling geographical footprint that incorporated parts of what are today eastern India, southern China, Thailand, Cambodia, and Laos. Factionalism, resource depletion, and maladministration in multiple areas combined to severely weaken

¹² Kautilya, *Kautilya’s Arthasāstra*, trans. R. Shamasastri (Bangalore: Government Press, 1915).

¹³ See Burton Watson (trans.), *Han Feizi: Basic Writings* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003) for a Chinese text mirroring Kautilya in many ways.

the dynasty by the 1740s, opening the way for peripheral territories to break away from the center.¹⁴

The mid-century wars following on Toungoo collapse involved a cornucopia of large and small states, whose rulers were locked in a deathly struggle with each other. All reached out to European trading corporations for alliance, precipitating their entrance into the region. The first to do so was the Tenasserim city-state of Tavoy, caught between larger neighbors demanding that it pay tribute. Its ruler offered the EIC lavish privileges in exchange for protection, a model of how informal imperial dominance could be established elsewhere by taking advantage of momentary desperation on the part of rulers whose security was threatened by internal or external forces.

The second was Pegu. Its bundle of relationships with three different trading corporations were the most ambiguous, embodying Sanjay Subrahmanyam's pattern of 'contained conflict,' where transactional dealmaking was punctuated by betrayal and violence.¹⁵ The Pegu court allied with the French, who used the opportunity to assess the potential for the kingdom's conquest; but

¹⁴ Victor B. Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles: Anarchy and Conquest, c. 1580–1760* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1984).

¹⁵ Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *The Political Economy of Commerce: Southern India, 1500–1650* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), ch. 5.

French forces in Pegu became rapidly subordinated to the court as French command structures disintegrated due to pressure from the English. Pegu alliance with the French also brought in the English, who were first courted by Pegu, then subject to coercive measures as the Company switched to courting Ava. The Ostenders, a band of desperados who evinced piratical intentions, were destroyed immediately on arrival.

The last to seek out support was the nascent Konbaung dynasty. This was by far the most powerful of the three under study in the paper, and expected unequivocal submission from Europeans it dealt with. This was a lopsided power relationship, the polar opposite of what prevailed in the colonial period. The dynasty drew the Company into an alliance in exchange for weapons, afterward harshly punishing it in response to receiving intelligence that local factors at Negrais had been aiding the Pegu rebellion. The ambition, ruthlessness and strategic acumen displayed by the dynasty's founder, Alaungpaya, perhaps best illustrates the article's central thesis: a would-be king, operating within a recognizably unique structural and cultural context, and yet displaying an acute awareness of what was necessary in order to secure and expand his fledgling domain.

PART 3. TAVOY AND THE EIC

The mid-18th-century prince of Tavoy, a small principality that had traditionally oscillated between the tributary control of Burma and Siam,¹⁶ was affiliated with the Toungoo court, the collapse of which plunged him into insecurity. Under pressure from both Pegu and Ava to pledge loyalty, he reached out to an English private trader in order to make contact with the Company, offering an agreement: he would enter into a diplomatic and political alliance, granting the Company rights to build a settlement and a tax-free monopoly over all trade in the kingdom. In return, the prince requested 100 cannon, 100 muskets, shot, powder, and a contingent of fifty soldiers, to be paid for by the Company (as well as a diamond ring worth 150 Madras pagodas, or half a kilogram of gold).¹⁷ The Company was willing to accept the privileges offered while simultaneously providing nothing in the way of concrete military support, save for a single, likely

¹⁶ Pamaree Surakiat, "Thai–Burmese Warfare during the Sixteenth Century and the Growth of the First Toungoo Empire," *Journal of the Siam Society* 93 (2005): 69–100.

¹⁷ King of Tavoy to Fort St. George, 31 January 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1910), 37–38.

ornamental, brass cannon and a carriage. They claimed that they were too tied up with the French in India to spare more resources.¹⁸

The king of Tavoy wrote a letter to Company officials at Madras, laying out the reasons that had led him to make his offer.¹⁹ He was a loyalist of the former Toungoo monarch, to whom he remained devoted even after the man had been captured and imprisoned in Pegu. He claimed that when the Pegu king sent an envoy to his court requiring him to send tribute in a display of allegiance, he delayed as long as he could, sending spies into Pegu who managed to communicate directly with the captive king. The latter advised him to seek out an alliance with the East India Company as their final hope.

Through the Tavoy ruler, the captive Toungoo monarch sent a message imploring the Company to liberate him, for which he was willing to give not only the port city of Syriam but also the entirety of Upper Burma, free from tribute or taxes. The raja recommended that if the Company was going to take the fallen monarch up on his offer, they should do so immediately, as a member of the

¹⁸ Fort St. George to the King of Tavoy, 12 June 1753, *Records of Fort St.*

George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753, 99.

¹⁹ King of Tavoy to Fort St. George, 29 January 1755, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1755* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912), 43.

Toungoo royal family had escaped the clutches of the Pegu government, raised an army in Siam, and was now marching back into Burma to recapture his birthright.

In later correspondence, the brother of the Pegu king provided insight into the nature of the conflict that had led to the Tavoy king and his erstwhile sovereign to reach out to the Company for help. As he explained:

"The Bermu King reigned in the Kingdom of Ava for a long time and acquired considerable wealth and an army... But, by the blessing of God and his Majesty's good luck, I marched to Ava and conquered the kingdom, taking the king, viziers, omras, and all his people prisoners, and seized all his effects, horses, elephants, guns, etc., and presented them to his Majesty at Pegu. The said King of Ava, together with the viziers and omras, submitted to his Majesty and drank the water of an oath. We took care of him in a favorable manner in every respect. Notwithstanding, he proved faithless and acted as an enemy, which was discovered at length. The said king, together with his viziers and omras, met with deserved punishment." ²⁰

²⁰ Letter from Apparaza, brother to the King of Pegu, to Fort St. George, 6 December 1755, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1756* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912), 8–9.

In 1759, the Tavoy prince was executed by Alaungpaya for rebellion.²¹ His calculated but ultimately doomed attempt to stave off claims by rival powers by volunteering to enter into a subordinate relationship with the Company was not outside the norm in the eighteenth century. Despite the growing presence of European powers, the biggest threats and opportunities still often emerged from local patterns. The EIC deftly took advantage of such fault lines to drive home concessions that would ultimately result in colonization of large chunks of India and beyond, but it did not conjure them up out of the aether. Company officials often became involved in the internal politics of Asian states at the invitation of participants angling for advantage in a fast-changing political landscape; one in which taking and maintaining power was difficult and risky, making patronage an attractive option even if it meant an erosion of sovereignty.²²

²¹ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598–1885*, vol. 3 (Kyoto: Center for Southeast Asian Studies, 1985), 64–65 (4 January 1760); 67–68 (7 January 1760); 68 (15 January 1760); 69 (19 January 1760); 70 (20 February 1760).

²² Andrew Phillips, *How the East Was Won: Barbarian Conquerors, Universal Conquest and the Making of Modern Asia* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2021); Peter J. Marshall, *Bengal: The British Bridgehead: Eastern India, 1740–1828* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988); C. A. Bayly, *Indian*

PART 4. PEGU AND THE CHARTERED COMPANIES

Emerging out of the disintegration of the Toungoo empire in the 1740s, the short-lived state of Pegu was destroyed by the nascent Konbaung dynasty a mere twenty years after its foundation in a harsh sack marked by imprisonments and the execution of many of its elites. However, in that short span, Pegu's rulers displayed remarkable political sophistication. They were in contact with three different European trading corporations—the English, French, and Ostenders—and used a flexible mix of strategies in dealing with each: violently disciplining the Ostenders; forging a transactional alliance with the French, solidified by ritual and backed by coercion; and engaging in a winding series of negotiations with the English that degenerated into open rupture after the Company double crossed them. The pragmatism, shrewdness and ruthlessness displayed by the Pegu king and his brother the crown prince suggests that they were well versed in the art of realpolitik, even if their ends were derived from Southeast Asian political tradition.

Pegu and the Ostenders

The shortest and bloodiest interaction was between the Pegu court and the remnants of the Ostend corporation, a small trading house that had been driven

Society and the Making of the British Empire (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988).

into exile after being attacked by the nawab of Bengal.²³ Mr. Schonamille, their leader, contacted the EIC and said that he planned to relocate to Pegu. He offered to exercise leverage in the kingdom on English behalf, blocking out other European powers, though the offer was declined; the EIC viewed the Ostenders as “dissolute” and was investigating Ostend agents suspected of trying to illegally purchase weapons in Madras.²⁴

Shortly after their arrival, they were invited to the Pegu capital for an audience with the king. When they arrived, they were told that he had gone hunting and would return to meet with them in a day or two. Suspecting treachery, they tried to return to their boats but found them beached; they were then ambushed by the riverside and slaughtered. The handful that survived scattered

²³ Gijs Dreijer, “The Afterlife of the Ostend Company, 1727–1745,” *The Mariner’s Mirror* 105, no. 3 (2019): 275–87.

²⁴ Consultation at Fort St. George, 21 January 1745, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department, 1745* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1931), 19; Schonamille to Morse, 2 January 1745, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department, 1745*, 26; Consultation at Fort St. George, 17 April 1745, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department, 1745*, 70–72.

across Asia, some turning up in Madras to tell the tale of their destruction.²⁵

Several years later, the Pegu monarch, in conversation with a French official, explained the motive for this attack: the offenders had, under the pretext of “amity and alliance,” tried to impose their law in his kingdom.²⁶

European trading corporations often walked a thin line between trade and piracy. The most powerful and bureaucratized of them, the English EIC, tended to pursue its predatory aims in an orderly fashion, but conquistador-like personal ambition was present there as well, and on a massive scale.²⁷ In other cases, such as that of the Portuguese in an earlier era,²⁸ lack of bureaucratic control led to widespread devolution of the quest for wealth and power to the individual or

²⁵ Consultation at Fort St. George, 29 July 1745, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department, 1745*, 129–31.

²⁶ “Mémoires sur le Pégou,” in *Revue de l’Extrême-Orient*, ed. Henri Cordier, vol. 2 (Paris: E. Leroux, 1884), 508.

²⁷ Nicholas B. Dirks, *The Scandal of Empire: India and the Creation of Imperial Britain* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2006), esp. chs. 1, 2.

²⁸ Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *The Portuguese Empire in Asia, 1500–1700: A Political and Economic History*, 2nd ed. (Chichester & Malden, MA: Wiley–Blackwell, 2012).

factional level. This was likely the case with the Ostenders, who were possibly involved in piracy, among other illegal activities, such as flying ships under false flags, using forged passports, operating out of multiple European ports to evade detection, and circumventing monopoly restrictions.²⁹

The exact details of what precipitated the Pegu court's decision to attack the Ostenders can only be guessed at. But given Schonamille's offer to exercise sway over Pegu on behalf of the EIC, it is likely that they were correctly surmised as a threat, which, combined with the carefully planned and bloody strategy through which they were dealt with, reveals an adroitness on the part of the Pegu king and his brother befitting of self-made rulers who had risen from relatively humble origins.

Pegu and the French

Throughout most of its brief life, the Pegu court's main European ally was the French East India Company. This was an alliance solicited by the Pegu court itself, which in the early 1750s sent envoys to the French at Pondicherry, asking for aid in their war against Ava.³⁰ The Marquis Dupleix, architect of an

²⁹ Gijs Dreijer, "The Afterlife of the Ostend Company, 1727–1745," *The Mariner's Mirror* 105, no. 3 (2019): 275–87.

³⁰ Alfred Albert Martineau, *Dupleix et l'Inde française: 1749–1754*, Tome III (Paris: Société d'éditions géographiques, maritimes et coloniales, 1927), 449–51.

aggressive, expansionist strategy to combat the English in India through intervening in local conflicts,³¹ seized on the opportunity, sending the Sieur de Bruno to negotiate with the kingdom on behalf of the French Company, accompanied by an Italian Barnabite missionary named Paulo de Nerini.

This was both a diplomatic and a spying mission, meant to assess the possibility of conquest.³² Nerini, who had long been resident in the kingdom, passed along intelligence that the king was not securely in possession of his throne: he was being challenged by multiple internal and external rivals, and his brother was the true power behind him. He gave Bruno a frank estimate of the kingdom's disposition of forces, where their weaknesses lay, and what it would take to overcome them. Bruno observed that conscription and corvée labor had left the population disaffected and ripe for revolt, and explained where to position fortifications and cannon installations should the French decide to invade, concluding that several hundred well-equipped French troops would likely be able to take the city of Syriam; they could then place gun batteries on the surrounding high ground that would allow them to command adjacent river traffic.

The Pegu court was not unaware of the unreliability of European offers of alliance. In a preliminary audience, the Apporaza, brother of the Pegu king, had

³¹ Ternat, "Lettre d'or et canon."

³² "Mémoires sur le Pégou," in *Revue de l'Extrême-Orient*, vol. 2, 505–13.

the envoys translate Dupleix's letter into Mon via multiple languages to allay his suspicions. He appeared surprised at the liberal terms being offered, and asked to what extent the French could provide him troops and weapons to aid in the court's war against Ava. In later conversations, the king of Pegu revealed that they had been double-crossed twice before, first by the English at the outset of the conflict, then by the Ostenders. The French actively sought to exploit this fear, suggesting to the Apporaza that Ostender ships would come with English aid to avenge Schonamille's death. The threat was taken seriously, with the court making plans to fortify an island at the mouth of the Syriam river to head them off.³³

In his audience with the Pegu monarch, Bruno described having the French Company's letter read aloud multiple times in a palace reception room packed with nobles as well as ambassadors from the Konbaung dynasty, who had been imprisoned but were released to witness the ceremony; this was intended to impress upon them the fact that the French were now on Pegu's side. Afterward, Bruno was led up to a temple on a hill in the Pegu palace grounds and there was administered an oath of allegiance. He read a formula written on yellow paper, which was then burned. The ashes were mixed into water held in a small gold

³³ Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 5 January 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753*, 28–30.

cup; the water had been taken from a basin containing a cannon, a rifle, a lance, and bullets. He then drank the concoction, pledging his loyalty to the king.

Soon afterward, the Apporaza attended a feast at Nerini's house. During the festivities, he also bound himself ritually to Bruno, this time in a church in a ceremony explicitly tied to the Christian faith. The intent behind this syncretic ritual was military in nature. Immediately after, the Apporaza told Bruno that he planned to march with an army of tens of thousands on Ava, and wanted as many weapons as possible to aid in his campaign.

Burmese chronicles capture the importance of foreign fighters to the Mon military effort. The Pegu army was described as having foreign commanders, likely at the head of mercenary battalions.³⁴ Foreign cannoneers are mentioned as having formed part of Pegu naval forces around the city of Prome.³⁵ Three hundred foreign fighters were reported to have been killed in an ambush during skirmishes around the city of Syriam.³⁶ French warships fought alongside the Peguans in their attacks on Rangoon. Propaganda leaflets, some of which were written in European languages, were released into Syriam to demoralize its

³⁴ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 4th ed. (Yangon: Universities Historical Research Centre, 2004), 126.

³⁵ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 120.

³⁶ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 144.

defenders.³⁷ The city itself was defended by seven large French vessels, strategically positioned to create overlapping fields of fire that made it difficult to approach the city walls. In the final storming of the city, the French vessels were boarded by Burmese fighters, who took them in fierce hand-to-hand combat, their crews afterward jumping into the ocean to try to save themselves.³⁸

Inventories of goods taken from defeated Pegu troops provide insight into the extent of the material support provided by the expeditionary force. After the defeat of the French ships defending Syriam, 80 large and 100 small cannons, over 1,000 muskets, large numbers of gold and silver coins, and hundreds of boxes of textiles, worth 5,000 tikals (or 80 kilograms of gold) were captured. Inside the city, troops seized more war material likely of European origin: cannons, muskets, powder, and bullets. Also seized were technologically advanced items likely associated with the European presence in Syriam, such as naval equipment, as well as glass globes, lanterns, mirrors, and gold and silver casings, taken from wealthy merchants for use in the king's apartments.³⁹

During the sack of Syriam, orders were given to spare innocent segments of the population—the elderly, sick, children, and monks—but to round up

³⁷ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, xvii.

³⁸ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 150, 152.

³⁹ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 156–8.

wealthy foreign merchants, men and women alike, and to requisition their gold, silver, precious stones, and trade goods. Among the foreign captives were ship captains, sailors, gunsmiths, tailors, goldsmiths, silversmiths, painters, sculptors, turners, blacksmiths, architects and Europeans affiliated with trading corporations operating in the city. Over 1,000 individuals were reportedly captured.⁴⁰

Three French warships that arrived to reinforce Syriam too late were also captured; Bruno, then being held captive, was forced to write letters luring them into the harbor.⁴¹ They were fully loaded with weaponry and trade goods, including large and small cannons, rifles, gunpowder drums, mortars, explosive shells, cannonballs, textiles, parasols, porcelain, odd puppets, spyglasses, swords, gun carriages, bayonets, two million sheets of paper, and bullion.⁴² Three hundred sailors, as well as three ship captains, were taken prisoner. The officers of the ships were executed, along with Bruno and Nerini.⁴³ The rank-and-file, Indian and French, were brought back to Ava.

⁴⁰ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 156–8.

⁴¹ Michael Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava in the Year 1795*, vol. 1 (Edinburgh: Constable & Co., 1827), 40–3.

⁴² Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 156–8.

⁴³ Hall, “The Tragedy of Negrais,” 98.

The extent of the French involvement in this conflict does not seem to have been a matter of deliberate policy. The heads of the French East India Company wrote to Pondicherry in 1753 to voice their disapproval of any attempt to make France the sole master of trade in the region through the use of military force. The French presence in Pegu was supposed to be limited to trade and shipbuilding. They did not want an alliance with either the Peguans or the Burmese, nor did they want French representatives on the coast to attempt to use their political clout with local rulers to edge out the English.⁴⁴ Other French documents from the period refer to Bruno as having violated the terms of neutrality that he was supposed to uphold.⁴⁵ A French envoy sent to Burma in 1770 to negotiate for the release of soldiers and sailors captured by the Burmese told Hsinbyushin, the third monarch of the Konbaung dynasty, that French soldiers in Pegu had revolted against their captain, that Bruno was a fool who deserved his death and that the French nation itself had never intended to wage war against Burma.⁴⁶

⁴⁴ Martineau, *Dupleix et l'Inde française*, Tome III, 449–51.

⁴⁵ Pierre Sonnerat, *Voyage aux Indes orientales et à la Chine, fait par ordre du Roi, depuis 1774 jusqu'en 1781*, vol. 2 (Paris: Chez l'Auteur, 1782), 40.

⁴⁶ "Mémoires sur le Pégou," in *Revue de l'Extrême-Orient*, vol. 2, 548, 529.

In part Bruno's fate was due to the French Company's bureaucratic fragmentation. By the 1750s, it was losing in the Anglo-French conflict. Its operations all over the Indian Ocean were being disrupted by English pressure; twenty years later, bankrupt from its failed competition with the English, it would be disbanded.⁴⁷ Compounding this was possibly personal ambition: many of Bruno's contemporaries fighting in the proxy wars playing out across the Deccan rose to positions of extraordinary power as kingmakers, achieving personal wealth and notoriety.⁴⁸ Statements made by later envoys accusing Bruno of disobedience suggest that his overly deep involvement in Pegu's war was disapproved of by his peers.

The bigger causal factor here however was the Pegu court's sophisticated political acumen. Motivated by its rivalry with the looming Konbaung dynasty to the north, Pegu's rulers took the initiative to send envoys to Pondicherry in order

⁴⁷ Danna Agmon and Philip J. Stern, "The East India Companies and the Seven Years' War," in *The Oxford Handbook of the Seven Years' War*, eds. Trevor Burnard, Emma Hart, and Marie Houllemare (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2024), 285–302.

⁴⁸ Robert Ivermee, "Gifts, Sovereignty and Power: The British and French Trading Companies in Mughal India, 1735–65," *Revue française de civilisation britannique* 29, no. 3 (2024): 63–75.

to garner support for their war effort. Cognizant of the unreliability of European alliances, the Pegu king and his brother subordinated Bruno to their will, both symbolically and politically. The rituals Bruno underwent were not hollow form; they were intended to bind his loyalties and expected to actually govern his actions. When he balked at his obligations to continue fighting, Bruno was disciplined. As the siege of Syriam progressed and he sensed that his situation was dire, he tried to secretly parley with Alaungpaya. When the Pegu king discovered this, he had Bruno carried into the town's citadel and imprisoned.⁴⁹

An entire French expeditionary force was lost in Pegu, destroyed and absorbed into Konbaung labor control networks. Bruno was, according to rumor, roasted alive. Nerini was beheaded.⁵⁰ Hundreds of French and Indian soldiers, sailors, and laborers were captured, along with large amounts of war materiel and the accumulated wealth of a major trade entrepot. French ambitions in Burma may have been imperialistic, but they ended here after crossing another, locally hegemonic state-building project.

Pegu and the English

The Pegu rebellion against the Toungoo dynasty sought outside support from the beginning. In the 1740s, the Company operated a shipyard in Syriam

⁴⁹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, vol. 1, 40–3.

⁵⁰ Hall, "The Tragedy of Negrais," 98.

under a contractor named Mr. Smart. He was contacted shortly after the outbreak of the rebellion in Pegu by Smim Htaw Buddhaketi, a Mon monk who had been raised to the throne. The new king expressed his willingness to delegate to Mr. Smart the governance of all foreigners in the port, and promised to give preferred treatment to those trading under the Company's flag. This included a flat customs reduction, exemption from the usual practice of having to give gifts to officials involved in the regulation of trade, and the ability to trade in any commodities free of government regulation. In return, the king wanted an alliance against the Burmese, whom he described as having murderous intent against his people and other ethnic groups in the kingdom.⁵¹

In 1741, Mr. Smart reported that the Toungoo governor of Syriam had his settlement's weapons and gunpowder requisitioned for the city's defense. As the Pegu army poured into the gates of the town, he was visited by its governor, who, out of desperation, tried to convince him to come to his aid. On his refusal, he witnessed the prince jump into the river, swim to a small boat, and flee.

⁵¹ Letter from Jonathan Smart to Fort St. George, 23 December 1740, with appended letter from King Sementho to Jonathan Smart, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 26 (1741) (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1916), 8–9.

Mr. Smart was suspected by his employers of having become improperly embroiled in the conflict.⁵² The Pegu king in conversations with Bruno later referred to Mr. Smart by name as someone who had double-crossed him, possibly because of his providing aid to the Toungoo governor.⁵³ This is likely why, in 1744, when the Peguers retook the town after a pitched battle, they seized the factory, disarmed its guards, carried off their weapons, broke into and plundered its storehouses, burned them, and then threw Mr. Smart to the ground, attempting to run him through. He barely escaped with his life. In his final letter to Madras, he reported that he had been imprisoned in a horse stable. He was planning his escape from the country, which he described as being at war in every direction.⁵⁴

In the late 1740s, in response to the French alliance with Pegu, officials in Madras conceived of the idea to return to Pegu. Their goal was to seize control of the island of Negrais, strategically located at the mouth of the Irrawaddy River. A planning document described the last Toungoo monarch as weak and the state as

⁵² Jonathan Smart to Fort St. George, 17 March 1741, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 26 (1741), 35–37.

⁵³ "Mémoires sur le Pégou," in *Revue de l'Extrême-Orient*, vol. 2, 505–13.

⁵⁴ Jonathan Smart to Fort St. George, 14 January 1744, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 28 (1744) (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1931), 30–31.

collapsing, leaving behind a power vacuum in which no party would be strong enough to oppose their designs. It surmised that, because of its offshore location, Negrais could be defended against a much larger attacking army, and, due to its proximity to the Company's bases in India, it could be defended against European rivals as well. Situated directly in the middle of coastal trade routes into Burma, the island could be used to blockade port cities and stop shipments of food up the Irrawaddy River in order to pressure Burmese rulers. The settlement could be used to reroute trade away from Burma's port cities, and drain the coast of population by providing refuge to those fleeing the conflict. These refugees were to be used—along with European private traders and Indians from the Coromandel Coast—as the founding population of a new port surrounded by a hinterland of pepper plantations worked by African slaves.⁵⁵

Robert Westgarth, a private trader who had long been resident in Pegu, was tasked with initially representing the Company in negotiations to retroactively legitimate the unilateral seizure of the island. He reported that the king was suspicious of their intentions. The king pointed out that Negrais was

⁵⁵ “The Consequence of Settling an European Colony on the Island Negrais,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 129–32; African slaves are mentioned as having escaped from the island in Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, vol. 1, 18.

empty jungle, unsuitable for trade, and questioned what the Company's purpose in choosing such a location was. He and his brother, who remembered earlier Portuguese predations in the region,⁵⁶ urged the Company to settle on the mainland. Local officials also suspected the Negrais settlement. Thomas Taylor reported that nearly a thousand Pegu soldiers had been stationed on nearby islands; he was warned by his interpreter that if he could not get permission from the king for occupying the island, he could be attacked. His handful of men were sick and dying, and in no shape to put up a fight; he was summoned to the Pegu court in order to obtain it.⁵⁷

⁵⁶ Henry Brooke to Fort St. George, 11 January 1754, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1911), 15–17.

⁵⁷ Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 1 September 1752, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1910), 59–60; Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 16 September 1752, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752*, 60–61; Thomas Taylor to Fort St. George, 14 September 1752, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752*, 61–62; Fort St. George to Thomas Taylor, 29 October 1752, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military*

In their dealings with Company officials, the king and his brother displayed a pragmatic willingness to trade away the island on the condition that the Pegu king was recognized as its ultimate suzerain and received significant compensation. They wanted a letter and gifts to be sent from Madras, specifically acknowledging that the island was granted to the Company by the king.⁵⁸ They also wanted reciprocal trade privileges so they could send ships to Madras each year (one was sent under an English captain to Madras to buy diamonds,

Department, 1752, 62; Fort St. George to Robert Westgarth, 29 October 1752, Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752, 63.

⁵⁸ Thomas Taylor to Fort St. George, 30 September 1752, in *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752, 81–82; Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 10 October 1752, Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753, 16–17.*

flintlocks and iron, likely for casting cannonballs; ⁵⁹ another, under Armenian, Portuguese and South Indian officers, sought to purchase 1000 muskets). ⁶⁰

Instead of offering anything of value, in 1753 the Company drew up an egregiously one-sided treaty to present to the king. It asserted the right to multiple settlements in the kingdom, forbade the Peguan government from involving itself in the Company's internal affairs or asserting its rule over English subjects, gave the East India Company permission to administer the estates of any English subjects who died in the kingdom, cut in half the Company's customs duties, granted it freedom of movement and trade in all parts of the kingdom, and gave it permission to imprison Peguan debtors. It also bonded all Indian subjects working for the Company, forbidding them from deserting into Pegu. In return, the treaty gave nothing. ⁶¹

⁵⁹ Letter from Pegu, 8 February 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1753* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1911), 15.

⁶⁰ Apporaza to Fort St. George, 25 February 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1753*, 41.

⁶¹ "Preliminary Articles Agreed to by Upper Rajah, 1 October 1752," *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753*, 17–18.

The king's brother wrote a perplexed letter to the Company, asking why they would try to present his king with a treaty from which he had nothing to gain. All of the clauses in it, he wrote, were purely for the benefit of the Company. It wanted to settle and fortify Negrais, drain the surrounding countryside of population to create a new port town not under the king's control, reroute trade into its hands, and have total liberty to trade in the kingdom in any goods they pleased while avoiding customs—all while receiving security guarantees from the Peguan court. He wrote that if the Company was willing to present him with a document that was also beneficial to his king, he would consider representing it to him; otherwise, it would never reach his eyes. He concluded by explaining what that benefit should be: a detachment of "white and black musketeers," together with 1,000 firelocks within two months, so that he could punish "traitors" who had appeared in various parts of his country.⁶²

Rejection of the treaty led to a prolonged deadlock in which both the English and the French made liberal use of gift-giving in order to influence outcomes. At the outset of the mission, the heads of the Madras settlement ordered the construction of two lavishly decorated palanquins worth in total 1400

⁶² Wopparaja, Brother to the King of Pegu, to Fort St. George, 20 January 1754, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1754* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912), 61–62.

Madras pagodas (5.4 kg of gold) and made of teak, ornamented with ivory, tortoiseshell, rubies, velvet, scarlet, China silk, gold leaf, and silver thread.⁶³ The final round of treaty negotiations was accompanied by another large shipment of gifts, including luxury cloth and European curiosities: a musical clock, a curious agate cabinet set in gold, a brass-mounted gun, a silver-mounted gun, a pair of silver-mounted pistols, and a gold watch ornamented with mocha stone. These were worth over 600 Madras pagodas, or 2 kilograms of gold.⁶⁴ The French promised similar luxury goods, including diamonds and fine clothing.⁶⁵ The most common gifts were military supplies—guns, pistols, cannon, powder, and shot. It is unclear exactly how many of these were gifted to the Pegu government, but a

⁶³ “Particulars of a Palankeen provided for the King of Pegue ... and Particulars of a Palankeen provided for the Upper Rajah at Pegue,” *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department, 1753* (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1941), 264–66.

⁶⁴ “List of Presents to the King of Pegue and Uppa Razah sent under the Care of Coja Nicoose,” *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754*, 169.

⁶⁵ Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 5 January 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753*, 28–30.

Burmese bureaucratic document suggests that the French alone gifted upwards of 60 mounted cannons and hundreds of muskets.⁶⁶

Other tactics included deception, rumormongering, even possible assassination attempts. English envoys were instructed to tell the Pegu king that signing a treaty would result in a flood of mercantile wealth into his kingdom, just as it had with the Mughals, “infinitely more than leveling a trifling custom on trade.”⁶⁷ The Company induced one of its main proxies on the Coromandel Coast, the Nawab of Arcot, to write a letter to the Pegu king warning that the French had tried to oust him from power: “I am informed that the French have the same design on your country,” he wrote. “Therefore, I thought it just to acquaint you of it that you may provide against it. You may rely on the English; whatever engagements they make with you, they will fulfill, and their courage will be a bulwark to you against your enemies.”⁶⁸ Rumors even surfaced of a French plot to ship poisoned food to the Negrais factory. The source for this was an Englishman named John Granger, who claimed to have overheard a conversation

⁶⁶ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 6–7 (6 June 1755).

⁶⁷ Fort St. George to Henry Brooke, 25 March 1754, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754*, 72–74.

⁶⁸ Letter to the King of Pegu by Nabob Aneverdry Cawn, 10 March 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753*, 27.

to this effect in the Sieur de Bruno's house, after which he jumped out a window.

69

The king and his brother, described in Company correspondence as eloquent and politically astute, played the same game of deception.⁷⁰ They collected information on English activities in India, filibustered envoys, issued contradictory orders, and deftly played the English and French off each other, giving mutually exclusive promises of friendship to both while absorbing a small fortune in gifts, favoring whichever of the English or French was more liberal in their spending at any given time, and attempting to extract military support from each. They also deliberately stoked their paranoia of one other. The Apporaza stated in an audience with Westgarth that the French had also requested the island of Negrais; the king then slyly told the English envoy in another that the French had never actually asked for the place, and that his brother had only said so to keep the English “in suspense.”⁷¹

⁶⁹ Robert Westgarth to Fort St. George, 2 January 1754, *Records of Fort St.*

George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754, 17–18.

⁷⁰ Thomas Taylor to Fort St. George, 5 January 1753, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1753, 30–32.*

⁷¹ Thomas Taylor to Fort St. George, 30 September 1752, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1752, 81–82.*

The unwillingness of Company servants on the Burma coast to offer the Pegu court more favorable terms led to its bypassing them and sending a pair of envoys to Madras to negotiate directly with its governor, Thomas Saunders. These envoys' strategy was much the same as the court's: to trade away bits of territory in return for concrete economic or political returns, as well as an acknowledgment of the overarching sovereignty of the Pegu monarch over any ceded land. In conversations with Saunders, the envoys made it clear that the king was willing to grant the Company extensive trade privileges, but only on the condition that it provide something of equal value in return. Saunders responded to this by adding to his list of demands the entire port town of Bassein and its hinterland.⁷² A new treaty was hashed out along these lines, granting the Company the island of Negrais, the town of Bassein, and permission to fortify both, as well as free and unlimited trade privileges in the kingdom without having to pay customs duties. In return, the Company promised to provide the king with a large annual shipment of gifts, to aid him in his wars against all his enemies by both sea and land, and to furnish troops and military supplies.⁷³

⁷² Commentary on these meetings can be found in *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754*, 84, 86.

⁷³ Fort St. George Consultation of 20 July 1754, *Records of Fort St. George: Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department, 1754*, 166–68.

Saunders then wrote a letter to the Pegu king lamenting that he had wanted to send troops and weapons, but as the envoys were traveling on a ship carrying French colors, he was compelled to withhold the agreed-upon support until an undisclosed later date.⁷⁴ Thus, the envoys returned to the Pegu capital with no concrete alliance in hand and a treaty with even more exorbitant demands. After this, negotiations broke down completely. The East India Company headquarters in London was informed that, unless reduced to a state of desperation by failure in their war with the Burmese, the brothers were unlikely to continue entertaining the Company's proposals.⁷⁵

In the later stages of the conflict between Ava and Pegu, both sides turned to coercive tactics in order to secure military support from European ships moored in the harbors of southern Burma. After Alaungpaya's capture of Rangoon, he sent for the occupants of several English ships docked there. Their captains and principal passengers went ashore to meet with him; while they were gone, their boats were boarded by the king's men, who tried to requisition their weapons and

⁷⁴ Fort St. George to the King of Pegu, 25 July 1754, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1754*, 134.

⁷⁵ Despatch from George Pigot, etc., to the Company, 10 March 1755, in *Calendar of the Madras Despatches*, ed. Henry Dodwell, 1744–1755, vol. 1 (Madras: Madras Government Press, 1920), 255–60.

ammunition, leading to a tense standoff. The ships' commanders were detained and their weapons confiscated, while Alaungpaya made contact with the head of the factory at Negrais in order to commence negotiations over weapons.⁷⁶ They exchanged pleasantries and gifts; Alaungpaya's letters made only passing reference to the captive sailors, claiming they had been caught in a storm, needed repairs, and had been "honored guests" ever since.⁷⁷

When the Pegu army appeared at Rangoon alongside a flotilla of French warships, they surrounded the English vessels and commandeered them, forcing them to turn their guns on the Burmese. The Apporaza sent messages to the commanders of the ships, ordering them to prepare for war and stating that if they refused, he would station contingents of soldiers on board. According to the captains, they were compelled in this way to join the French in bombarding the town for seven straight days, afterward retreating with the fleet back to Syriam.

The Pegu court then used the English crews as diplomatic bargaining chips. During their meeting with the Apporaza, the officers of the captured ships were assailed with accusations that the English were assisting his enemies. The prince again tabled his offer for trade privileges in return for military aid and sent

⁷⁶ The following affair is reconstructed from a narrative and attached letters in "English Proceedings at Dagon," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 177–201.

⁷⁷ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 6–7 (6 June 1755).

letters to that effect to the Negrais settlement. The head of the factory wrote back that he was unwilling to conclude a treaty; he also asked for the return of all the weapons that had been requisitioned from the Company's former trading post in the town. The prince then detained the ships' occupants, refusing to let them go until a treaty was concluded. They consulted him for an audience again, plying him with gifts and asking to be released, but were refused. In the ensuing argument, the prince reportedly declared that they were his prisoners and owed him their lives.

The Pegu court retained the commandeered ships and used them in other attacks during its final days. A letter, written by the captain of the Arcot, one of the captive English ships, described how the Pegu king had compelled his ship and several others to attack Rangoon a second time, alongside an army of 10,000. After a pitched battle, the captured vessels were allowed to go free, but only after they left their weapons behind. A Frenchman traveling through Negrais later told the settlement's leadership that, by commandeering European ships in this manner, the Pegu king had been able to create a modestly sized fleet.

Pegu's rulers suspected that Company officials along the coast were beginning to side with the Burmese. In a letter to Madras, the brother of the Pegu king accused Company officials of shielding Burmese envoys from capture by the Pegu army and of fighting alongside the Burmese at Bassein. He claimed that when the Burmese conquered Rangoon, they looted vast amounts of gold, silver,

and precious stones donated to monasteries by the Toungoo monarchs and used that wealth to bribe the factory heads at Negrais to help them. According to him, the settlement's head, Mr. Brooke then sent artillery, matchlocks, and ammunition to the Burmese king, along with English gunners. He accused the ship captains he had rescued of desiring to go over to the Burmese and the residents at Negrais of being faithless and in league with the Burmese, entreating the Madras governor to act on his treaty obligations by sending troops and weapons immediately. "This is the time to yield your assistance to us," he wrote.⁷⁸

Assistance never came. In 1757, the Burmese army surrounded and laid siege to Pegu. The city was starved out, sacked, and looted. Court chronicles describe the rivers running blood-red and vultures circling overhead. Soldiers carried off many of the spoils, except for the weapons in the king's arsenals and the valuables in the royal palace, which were taken by Alaungpaya. Large numbers of the capital's residents were taken captive, especially skilled artisans or specialist service groups attached to the court who made art or performed ritual functions. The king himself was captured and forced to personally present his royal regalia, including a lion-headed ring studded with a massive emerald, to

⁷⁸ Letter from Apparaza, brother to the King of Pegu, to Fort St. George, 6 December 1755, *Records of Fort St. George: Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1756*, 8–9.

Alaungpaya in an audience in his own palace. The women of the king's harem, including his chief queen, were absorbed into the Konbaung court; some after having been captured attempting to flee the sack.⁷⁹ The Pegu king, and many of his courtiers, were later executed for plotting while being held at the Konbaung court.

The English EIC, the strongest of the three trading corporations covered in this section, deployed a highly Machiavellian suite of tactics in its dealings with Pegu. This included the unilateral seizure of coastal bases, the use of treatymaking as an instrument of informal empire, the instrumentalization of gift-giving traditions in order to influence political outcomes, and attempts to take advantage of momentary weakness on the part of losing players in local conflicts in order to create dependent proxies. At the interpersonal level, these tactics were actualized through manipulation, deception and double-crossing.

But the Pegu court was far from naïve in the pursuit of its own interests. Actions included: volunteering to enter into a subordinate relationship with the Company in exchange for protection when weak; recognizing the threat represented by the seizure of Negrais while simultaneously displaying pragmatic willingness to give it up in exchange for concrete war support; recognizing the nature of the unequal treaty that was offered to them and summarily rejecting it in

⁷⁹ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 187–97.

favor of demonstrated aid; playing the English and French off each other; bypassing local representatives through the dispatch of envoys directly to Madras; and rationally turning towards a more coercive approach, commandeering weapons and ships and taking hostages to use as bargaining chips, when it became clear that the English had turned to aiding their enemies.

The East India Company and the Pegu kingdom were operating within different sovereignty traditions: one, a world of geopolitical competition, global trade, extraterritorial enclaves, and concessions backed by weaponized legal instruments; the other, a more fluid world defined by the ebb and flow of personal authority, hierarchical patron–client ties constituted through ritual, the exchange of gifts, and service obligations. But both sides were able to achieve an approximate understanding of the other’s interests and motivations, even if not the deep cultural reasons behind them; and at the level of how they went about attempting to achieve their different ends, they used a very similar suite of tactics: transactional negotiation, petitioning, spying, appealing to self-interest, calculated public display, fomenting division, intimidation, coercion, and violence.

PART 5. THE KONBAUNG DYNASTY AND NEGRAIS

The Konbaung state was a large, expansionist empire explicitly patterned off the Toungoo at its height.⁸⁰ The early Konbaung monarchs engaged in an unbroken string of military campaigns against multiple surrounding states, including Manipur, Siam, Qing China and Pegu, the dynasty's main rival for power in the Irrawaddy valley. Firearms, especially artillery, were important in the conduct of these wars, but not easily obtained domestically, forcing an outward search for suppliers.⁸¹

Konbaung imperialism was driven by Buddhist eschatology and a universalizing ideology of kingship that envisioned other ethnic groups as subordinate components in a loose order arranged around the court;⁸² Europeans were considered a part of this order. They were expected to pay homage to the throne, deliver tribute—particularly weapons—in exchange for residency and

⁸⁰ Victor B. Lieberman, "Political Consolidation in Burma Under the Early Konbaung Dynasty, 1752–c. 1820," *Journal of Asian History* 30, no. 2 (1996): 152–68.

⁸¹ William J. Koenig, *The Burmese Polity, 1752–1819: Politics, Administration, and Social Organization in the Early Kon-baung Period* (Ann Arbor: Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, University of Michigan, 1990), ch. 1.

⁸² Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 20–21 (9 April 1756); Koenig, *The Burmese Polity*, ch. 3.

trade privileges, and not to impede the dynasty's efforts to extend political control over the region. Both the English and the French failed to meet these expectations, and were dealt with harshly through attacks on their settlements and the incorporation of survivors into networks of labor control centered on the court.

Diplomatic contacts between the English and the Konbaung dynasty were initiated by Alaungpaya himself in the midst of battles raging over the control of port towns in southern Burma. George Baker, who was in charge of the Company's small establishment in the port town of Bassein, reported that after its initial conquest, he was visited by 25 Burmese boats filled with soldiers, as well as four interpreters and two envoys. They brought a letter from Alaungpaya to the factory head at Negrais. Sometime later, they returned with a large honor guard and gifts of wax, ivory, jewelry, and other items, entreating Baker to come with them. He set out to accompany them upriver, beginning the first of the series of diplomatic exchanges between the two states.⁸³

Burmese royal orders provide insight into what the court hoped to gain through these exchanges: weapons. One noted the historical trade relationship between Burma and India, through which there had been an exchange of precious

⁸³ "Capt. George Baker's Observations at Persaim," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 133–142.

gems, amber, copper, gold, iron, rubies, and silver with cannons and matchlocks from Europe. This trade had been halted with the rebellion of the Mons, but as Alaungpaya had resubjugated all of Burma's ethnic groups to his rule—Manipuri, Shans, Chin, Kachin, and Mon alike—he desired its revitalization. Two ruby-studded hamsa bird figurines made of gold were sent to Negrais, as well as letters addressed to the directors of the East India Company and the head of the Negrais settlement offering the Company permission to carry on its import-export trade free of taxation if it continued the ancient practice of giving arms and ammunition as gifts.⁸⁴

Like the Peguans, the Burmese were cognizant of the rivalry between the English and French and attempted to leverage it. Another document requested the Company provide artillery for use in the siege of the Pegu capital. It asked for a large number of cannons of 20, 15, 10, and 3 lb caliber, and hoped that they would be given for the sake of amity. The letter noted that the French were helping the Pegu army with 60 cannons and 300 smaller guns with all the necessary ammunition, and asked the English to provide double that support. It disclosed at the end that the French had tried to parlay but were turned away, likely an attempt to coax the English into acting quickly.⁸⁵

⁸⁴ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 3–4 (4 March 1755).

⁸⁵ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 6–7 (6 June 1755).

After the Negrais massacre, the court pivoted once again to the French. A letter written on gold leaf and addressed to the governor of Pondicherry described longstanding trade connections between Burma and western mercantile nations, disrupted due to the Mon rebellion. It said that the Frenchman Bruno had sided with the rebels and was punished accordingly. However, this incident should not affect the friendship between Burma and France. Orders were given for trade between the two nations to resume as before.⁸⁶

In private conversations with envoys, Alaungpaya made it clear that he had invited the English to his capital to provide him with weapons. To Baker he explained that he planned to return to continue the siege of Pegu in six weeks and needed to replenish his stores immediately. If the Company were able to help him with this, he would grant factories at Bassein and Rangoon. He opened with a high demand for 1,000 muskets and 20 pieces of heavy artillery, which was haggled down to a slightly reduced number.⁸⁷ The second diplomatic mission sent to Alaungpaya under Lester was conceived of by the king himself, who wrote to the Negrais factory summoning one of its residents to meet with him. The king used his audience with Lester to put pressure on the Negrais settlement to speed

⁸⁶ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma*, vol. 3, 60 (20 December 1759).

⁸⁷ “Capt. George Baker’s Journal of a Joint Embassy to the King of the Buragmahns,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 154–56.

up arms shipments and inquire as to why ships he had sent to Madras to purchase weapons and powder had been detained.⁸⁸

Correspondence between the Negrais factory and its parent settlement in Madras indicates that the Burmese king frequently sent envoys there to purchase chests of gunpowder and demand that the Company make good on its promises of providing war material to him. In the closing days of his siege of the Pegu capital, these envoys told the factors that their providing large quantities of weapons, ammunition, and powder was key to receiving favorable treatment from the king. Over 1,000 lbs of gunpowder were sold in these transactions. Letters to Madras stressed the importance of maintaining a steady flow of arms to satisfy the king so that he would not set his sights on the settlement. These later letters warned that the Burmese were becoming harsher in their demands because the amount of gunpowder being given was insufficient; the king was reportedly becoming suspicious that they were not fully loyal to him. The factors warned that if demands for military supplies could not be satisfied, the consequences could be dire. A Protestant Portuguese interpreter named David Renno, who had briefly been imprisoned by Alaungpaya (an Indian servant of the Company was later imprisoned for allowing him to escape), told the Negrais factors that providing such gifts in sufficient quantity was the main demand that had been imposed on

⁸⁸ “Ensign Lester’s Embassy to Ava, 1757,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 201–13.

them, and if they did not make good on their obligations they were likely to be driven out.⁸⁹

In his negotiations with envoys, Alaungpaya also displayed a shrewd understanding of the Company's proto-imperial intentions in occupying the island of Negrais. He told Baker that he was suspicious of the island's fortifications. In his meeting with Lester, he asked him why the English did not leave Negrais and settle on the mainland. In his initial decree granting permission for the Company to operate in his kingdom, the island was conspicuously left out. Baker pushed him on that point and asked him to grant it to the Company. The king replied that it mattered little, as they had already seized it by force, but also that he cared little about what they did on the island as long as they remained loyal to him.⁹⁰

⁸⁹ Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 7 January 1757, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 37 (1757) (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1941), 9–11; Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 8 December 1757, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 37 (1757), 28–30; Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 30 March 1757, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 37 (1757), 83–86.

⁹⁰ “Capt. George Baker’s Journal of a Joint Embassy to the King of the Buragmahns,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 157–60; “Ensign Lester’s Embassy to Ava, 1757,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 213.

The king took steps to prevent the English from fortifying a factory they had been given at Bassein. The prince of the town had initially given the Company permission to occupy high ground overlooking the city. The Negrais settlement shipped over 9-pound cannons and ammunition. After the prince came back from an audience with the king, he reversed course, throwing so many obstacles in the way of finishing the fort's construction that the project was abandoned.⁹¹ The Company had to vacate the settlement after a war party of 27 boats threatened to burn and plunder it.⁹²

In Baker's meeting with Alaungpaya, he was pressed hard about English ships firing on Burmese troops at Rangoon, the king even producing spent cannonballs recovered from the battlefield for Baker to inspect. During their second meeting, the king confessed that he no longer trusted the English after the attack but was willing to give them a second chance to prove themselves as truly his friends. Baker noted that this distrust was not only confined to the king. The

⁹¹ Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 15 October 1756, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 36 (1756) (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1942), 156–58.

⁹² Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 14 February 1759, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 39 (1758–59) (Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1942), 68.

English captains' conduct at Rangoon had created a groundswell of resentment among other Burmese elites. Baker had to conciliate a general commanding thousands of troops with gifts as an apology for the affront.⁹³

One of the last communications sent from Negrais details how a renewed rebellion had broken out under a general who had served in the former Pegu army. Soon after the outbreak of the revolt, the rebels detached a small party to the island to negotiate with the English in secret. The envoys referred to their general as the new Pegu king and requested military assistance from the English, making extravagant promises in return. On their withdrawal, they left a spy on the island, who was discovered and arrested. He was suspected of asking local people questions about the Company's strength—the number of guns, powder, and soldiers they had. The letter concluded by begging the Company to relieve the settlement, as they were beset by enemies on all sides.⁹⁴

Shortly after, the settlement was subjected to a planned and coordinated attack. It began with a fake overture by an interpreter carrying a dummy letter. As

⁹³ “Capt. George Baker’s Journal of a Joint Embassy to the King of the Buraghmahns,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 146, 150–51; “English Proceedings at Dagon,” in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 198.

⁹⁴ Thomas Newton to Fort St. George, 13 February 1759, *Records of Fort St. George: Letters to Fort St. George*, vol. 39 (1758–59), 66–68.

the factors were eating with their Burmese counterparts, they were cut down at the dinner table. According to one survivor, several of those who survived the initial attack barricaded themselves in a room. After they surrendered and were taken prisoner, one was kicked off a 14-foot-high ladder and run through with a lance. They were then brought to a boat and taken into captivity upcountry. While this was happening, Burmese troops, many of whom had stealthily encircled the fort in advance, converged on it in an ambush. The settlement's residents were methodically massacred, causing a stampede of terrified victims to jump into the ocean and swim to boats moored in the harbor—most of these were Indian laborers, including women and children. The fort's guns were then turned on the ships in the harbor, likely by French members of the king's royal guard. The settlement was then put to the torch. Alves, who witnessed all this from the deck of his ship, walked through it the next day and found it scattered with corpses, some of whom he recognized. A dozen of them had been executed in an open space, hands cinched behind their backs. The settlement's weapons were gone.⁹⁵

The *Konbaungset Yazawin* describes a swift and brutal surprise attack on the factory using soldiers disguised as merchants, burning it to the ground and

⁹⁵ "Account of the Loss of Negrais," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 343–50; "Capt. Walter Alves's Proceedings in Ava, on an Embassy, 1760," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 355–61.

driving the survivors into the sea. Afterward, gold, silver, gemstones, fine textiles, cannons, muskets, ammunition, and gunpowder were looted from the settlement and returned to the mainland in seven barges. The soldiers who had conducted the attack were rewarded with gold bracelets, luxury clothing, and other valuables for their service before being dispatched to serve in another military campaign.

The chronicle points to territorial encroachment, lack of respect for royal authority, and aid to the Mons as being the key factors behind the attack on Negrais. It states that at no time had foreigners been given permission to establish a fortified presence on the island, though they had initially been tolerated because of the Burmese king's desire to nurture trade. They had failed to pay proper respect to the king and were considered heretics opposed to his religion. Crucially it notes that, upon interrogation, Mon prisoners of war confessed that the residents of the island had been providing military equipment to them.⁹⁶

Multiple letters collected during the course of the Alves embassy, which was sent to Burma in part to investigate the causes behind the attack, illustrate a common opinion among the Burmese elite: that the factors at Negrais had been acting disloyally. The Prince of Bassein accused the factors of aiding the Peguans, whom he described as rogues, renegades, and oath breakers who hid in the woods and robbed towns and villages. As a result, mischief befell them. He described the

⁹⁶ Maung Maung Tin, *Konbaung-set Maha Yazawindawgyi*, vol. 1, 130–32.

king's quarrel with the factors as a local issue, urging the Company not to harbor resentments and to return to trade (though he also suggested they start paying customs).⁹⁷

Naungdawgyi, Alaungpaya's son and successor, explained in a letter that the Negrais factors had refused to pay taxes, harassed local shipping, refused to make good on their tributary obligations to aid the Konbaung dynasty in war, and illicitly sold weapons to the Pegu rebels. He portrayed the massacre as inevitable retribution ("when you put a piece of wood in the fire, in which is a worm... it is burnt with the wood") and explained his conditions for return: 10,000 muskets, 1000 vis of steel, 1000 of iron, 1000 gunpowder sieves, and ammunition of all types.⁹⁸

In his audience with Alves, Naungdawgyi claimed that the settlement's leadership had been engaged in piracy, splitting with Peguan freebooters half of the spoils of capturing Burmese prizes.⁹⁹ He argued that they had sealed their

⁹⁷ "Prince of Persaim's Letter to Governor Pigot," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 397–98.

⁹⁸ "Translation of a Letter from the King of the Buraghmahns to the Governor of Madras," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 394–95.

⁹⁹ "Capt. Walter Alves's Proceedings in Ava, on an Embassy, 1760," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 372–77.

own fate through their misdeeds. After reading a letter delivered to him by Alves petitioning for redress, he said that he was:

"...surprised to think how the Governor of Madras, as he said in his letter, could have the face to demand any satisfaction, which he would not give; for that he looked on all that were killed at Negrais, whether guilty or innocent, as born to die there, and in that manner; and that he never would give himself any trouble to enquire further about the affair. His soldiers were not obliged to know who were guilty or who were not, neither did he expect they would enquire, but, in such cases, generally killed men, women, or children as they pleased."¹⁰⁰

However, Naungdawgyi also took pains to explain that he placed the weight of responsibility on the Negrais officials specifically. He welcomed the Company's return, reiterating his demands for arms in exchange, adding that he also wanted equipment and skilled artisans to domestically manufacture weapons, as well as horses, camels and other goods.

He offered a new settlement, but only in an unfortified location on the mainland. He also required Alves to leave at least two Englishmen behind as insurance. Reportedly, he told Alves that if he did not comply with this request, he would assume that it was because the Company had hostile intent towards him

¹⁰⁰ "Capt. Walter Alves's Proceedings in Ava, on an Embassy, 1760," in *Oriental Repertory*, vol. 1, 373–4.

and that Alves had been sent into the country with some design other than what he professed. Alves reported being obliged to comply with his demands out of fear for his own liberty.

The early Konbaung rulers, despite their being ensconced within a post-Taungoo political framework and discourses of Buddhist kingship typical of Southeast Asia, displayed a sharp awareness of the realities of power politics. They had two overarching incentives in dealing with the Company. The first was the procurement of arms amid multiple simultaneous military campaigns and internal pacification efforts. The other was proto-imperial encroachment. The court actively collected intelligence on the English via intermediaries and through interrogations of prisoners of war. Upon determining that the Company had usurped multiple Indian rulers and that local factors were likely selling arms to the Peguans, the Negrais settlement was attacked in cold-blooded but tactically sophisticated fashion. The court then pivoted to the French for its firearms needs, while simultaneously attempting to convince the English to resettle in the kingdom on more favorable terms—guaranteed by the leaving of Company hostages, who were successfully secured through intimidation.

Whether they understood this or not, Company agents at Negrais had been incorporated into the patron-client networks of the Konbaung state. In exchange for the right to reside and trade in the kingdom, they were expected to pay customs duties, play their part in supporting the dynasty's expansionary efforts,

and not to impede its establishment of control over the Irrawaddy valley. The Company may have been powerful in India. In Burma, its local representatives were operating on sufferance. When they failed to conform to the behavior expected of them, they were subject to the same punishment that would have been meted out to any other disloyal vassal.

CONCLUSION

The conflict emerging after the collapse of the Toungoo dynasty was high-stakes, zero-sum, and intensely personal. Political clashes were animated by rivalries between key figures and factions. Losers faced harsh score-settling: not only the dismantling of their kingdoms, with major urban sacks followed by mass looting and population transfers, but individual catastrophe, such as imprisonment, execution, and the breakup of royal households, including forced marriages and elite purges.

Trading corporations provided certain goods that could be of value in such a setting. Weapons, and the expertise required to make and use advanced weaponry at a high level, were crucial to the conduct of Southeast Asian warfare. Trading corporations could also offer political cover and military alliance, especially sought after by losing players who needed a patron to ensure their personal safety and continuation in power. Secondly, the presence of European merchants represented taxes, bullion, luxury flows and the possibility of deepening trade relations with India.

Trading corporations were both useful potential allies and imperial institutions with aggressive ambitions of their own. Burmese rulers' interactions with them reflected the twin reality of their danger and indispensability. They tried to recruit these institutions in the service of their interests while preventing them from developing independent power bases of their own. What follows is a brief inventory of the tactics used in securing these goals.

The Tavoy prince stalled and employed dissimulation and intrigue in order to sidestep demands from multiple courts while simultaneously secretly communicating with the fallen Toungoo monarch through spies and attempting to recruit the English into the conflict on his side, volunteering to become an imperial subordinate in exchange for survival; his failed quest ended in execution.

The last Toungoo monarch held out lavish and likely undeliverable promises in exchange for rescue while held captive in Pegu; he and many of his retinue were later executed for plotting.

The Pegu court conquered Ava, sacked its capital, requisitioned its resources and captured key segments of its population; deceptively entrapped and destroyed the Ostenders; reached out to both the French and English for support out of necessity despite awareness of the fickleness of European alliances; kept tabs on the European presence in their kingdom through intelligence gathering and translation monitoring; used ritual oaths to secure the French resident's loyalties, then imprisoned him for double-crossing them; recognized the

Company's proto-imperial intentions in occupying and fortifying Negrais; displayed pragmatic willingness to trade away the island in exchange for concrete military support; exploited Anglo-French rivalries; bypassed the Negrais settlement to negotiate directly with Madras; correctly recognized they had been betrayed; and rationally turned to coercive tactics in order to requisition the resources and support they needed, including taking hostages and commandeering ships.

The Burmese made arms-for-access the linchpin of their negotiating strategy with the English; sent ships abroad to purchase weapons; leaned on the Negrais settlement for weapons purchases in an intimidating fashion; used tributary conduits to siphon up more weapons; reduced the city of Syriam through blockades and purposeful demoralization of its defenders; seized large amounts of war material and loot, and large numbers of skilled workers in multiple city sacks; destroyed a French naval flotilla in hand-to-hand combat; executed French officers in spectacular public fashion; absorbed rank-and-file soldiers and sailors into the royal service elite; collected intelligence on English activity at Negrais and in India; surveilled communications; correctly calculated that the English presence was not in their interest; struck Negrais in a planned ambush conducted by soldiers masquerading as merchants; and invited both the French and English back into the kingdom on renewed terms more in line with their interests, to be guaranteed by hostages.

This was a consistent repertoire of realpolitik methods organized around six core patterns: (1) transactional, rapidly recalibrated alliances formed on pragmatic grounds and maintained only as long as they served immediate interests; (2) deception, manipulation, and intimidation: elaborate traps, false hospitality, stalling tactics, continued plotting under the mask of submission, coercing captured enemies to lure their own reinforcements to destruction, and action secured through threats; (3) information warfare: actionable political intelligence gathered through intermediaries, systematic cross-checking of interpreters' work to detect falsification, interrogation, surveillance, and propaganda-like tactics; (4) violence and coercion, including large- and small-scale military action, spectacular public punishment, detention, and hostage-taking; (5) resource accumulation: arms acquisition via diplomatic negotiations and tributary networks, systematic seizure of military assets, material wealth, and skilled laborers from conquered states; and (6) ritual and oath-taking employed as binding political technologies securing specific military outcomes.

States, even when emerging from vastly different sociological foundations, tend to display an underlying regularity in their function as vehicles for the accumulation of resources and the assertion of control over populations. So too does the power-seeking behavior of the elites who rule them. Such behavior responds to structurally conditioned incentives, and it is expressed

through culturally specific idioms, but it takes place on a shared field of realpolitik, defined by a clash of interests as much as of cultures.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- Agmon, Danna, and Philip J. Stern. "The East India Companies and the Seven Years' War." In *The Oxford Handbook of the Seven Years' War*, edited by Trevor Burnard, Emma Hart, and Marie Houllémare, 285–302. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2024.
- Anderson, Benedict R. O'G. "The Idea of Power in Javanese Culture." In *Culture and Politics in Indonesia*, 1–70. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1972.
- Aung-Thwin, Michael, and Maitrii Aung-Thwin. *A History of Myanmar Since Ancient Times: Traditions and Transformations*. London: Reaktion Books, 2012.
- Bayly, C. A. *Indian Society and the Making of the British Empire*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988.
- Burnard, Trevor, Emma Hart, and Marie Houllémare, eds. *The Oxford Handbook of the Seven Years' War*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2024.
- Candier, Aurore. "Convergences conceptuelles en Birmanie : la transition du xix^e siècle." *Moussons*, no. 16 (2010): 81–101.

- Charney, Michael W. *Powerful Learning: Buddhist Literati and the Throne in Burma's Last Dynasty, 1752–1885*. Ann Arbor: Centers for South and Southeast Asian Studies, University of Michigan, 2006.
- Charney, Michael W. *Southeast Asian Warfare, 1300–1900*. Leiden & Boston: Brill, 2004.
- Dalrymple, Alexander. *Oriental Repertory*. Vol. 1. London: G. Biggs, 1793–97.
- Dirks, Nicholas B. *The Scandal of Empire: India and the Creation of Imperial Britain*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2006.
- Dodwell, Henry, ed. *Calendar of the Madras Despatches, 1744–1755*. Vol. 1. Madras: Madras Government Press, 1920.
- Dreijer, Gijs. "The Afterlife of the Ostend Company, 1727–1745." *The Mariner's Mirror* 105, no. 3 (2019): 275–87.
- Geertz, Clifford. *Negara: The Theatre State in Nineteenth-Century Bali*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980.
- Goldstone, Jack A. *Revolution and Rebellion in the Early Modern World: Population Change and State Breakdown in England, France, Turkey, and China, 1600–1850*. Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1991.
- Hall, D. G. E. "The Tragedy of Negrais." *Journal of the Burma Research Society* 21, no. 3 (1931): 59–133.

- Hanks, Lucien M. "Merit and Power in the Thai Social Order." *American Anthropologist* 64, no. 6 (December 1962): 1247–61.
- Htin, Aung Maung. *The Stricken Peacock: Anglo–Burmese Relations, 1752–1948*. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1965.
- Ivermee, Robert. "Gifts, Sovereignty and Power: The British and French Trading Companies in Mughal India, 1735–65." *Revue française de civilisation britannique* 29, no. 3 (2024): 63–75.
- Kauṭilya. *Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra*. Translated by R. Shamasastri. Bangalore: Government Press, 1915.
- Kirichenko, Alexey. "From Ava to Mandalay: Toward Charting the Development of Burmese Yazawin Traditions." *Journal of Burma Studies* 13, no. 1 (2009): 1–75.
- Koenig, William J. *The Burmese Polity, 1752–1819: Politics, Administration, and Social Organization in the Early Kon–baung Period*. Ann Arbor: Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, University of Michigan, 1990.
- Leach, Edmund R. *Political Systems of Highland Burma: A Study of Kachin Social Structure*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press for the London School of Economics and Political Science, 1954.
- Leider, Jacques P. "Buddhist Diplomacy: Confrontation and Political Rhetoric in the Exchange of Letters between King Alaungmintaya and King Banya Dala of Pegu (1755–56)." In *Buddhist Dynamics in Premodern and Early*

Modern Southeast Asia, edited by D. Christian Lammerts, 373–416.

Singapore: ISEAS Publishing, 2015.

Leider, Jacques P. *King Alaungmintaya's Golden Letter to King George II (7 May 1756): The Story of an Exceptional Manuscript and the Failure of a Diplomatic Overture*. Hannover: Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz Bibliothek, 2009.

Lieberman, Victor B. *Burmese Administrative Cycles: Anarchy and Conquest, c. 1580–1760*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1984.

Lieberman, Victor B. "Political Consolidation in Burma Under the Early Konbaung Dynasty, 1752–c. 1820." *Journal of Asian History* 30, no. 2 (1996): 152–68.

Lieberman, Victor B. *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, c. 800–1830*. Vol. 1, *Integration on the Mainland*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003.

Lieberman, Victor B. *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, c. 800–1830*. Vol. 2, *Mainland Mirrors: Europe, Japan, China, South Asia, and the Islands*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009.

Marshall, Peter J. *Bengal: The British Bridgehead: Eastern India, 1740–1828*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988.

Martineau, Alfred Albert. *Dupleix et l'Inde française: 1749–1754*. Tome III. Paris: Société d'éditions géographiques, maritimes et coloniales, 1927.

Maung Maung Tin. *Konbaung–set Maha Yazawindawgyi*. Vol. 1. 4th ed. Yangon:

Universities Historical Research Centre, 2004.

"Mémoires sur le Pégou." *Revue de l'Extrême–Orient* 2 (1884): 505–72.

Okell, John. *A Guide to the Romanization of Burmese*. London: Royal Asiatic

Society of Great Britain and Ireland, 1971.

Phillips, Andrew. *How the East Was Won: Barbarian Conquerors, Universal*

Conquest and the Making of Modern Asia. Cambridge: Cambridge

University Press, 2021.

Records of Fort St. George: *Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1753*.

Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1911.

Records of Fort St. George: *Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1754*.

Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912.

Records of Fort St. George: *Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1755*.

Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912.

Records of Fort St. George: *Country Correspondence, Military Department, 1756*.

Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1912.

Records of Fort St. George: *Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department,*

1752. Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1910.

Records of Fort St. George: *Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department,*

1753. Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1910.

Records of Fort St. George: *Diary and Consultation Book, Military Department,*

1754. Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1911.

Records of Fort St. George: *Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department,*

1745. Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1931.

Records of Fort St. George: *Diary and Consultation Book, Public Department,*

1753. Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1941.

Records of Fort St. George: *Letters to Fort St. George.* Vol. 26 (1741). Madras:

Superintendent, Government Press, 1916.

Records of Fort St. George: *Letters to Fort St. George.* Vol. 28 (1744). Madras:

Superintendent, Government Press, 1931.

Records of Fort St. George: *Letters to Fort St. George.* Vol. 36 (1756). Madras:

Superintendent, Government Press, 1942.

Records of Fort St. George: *Letters to Fort St. George.* Vol. 37 (1757). Madras:

Superintendent, Government Press, 1941.

Records of Fort St. George: *Letters to Fort St. George.* Vol. 39 (1758–59).

Madras: Superintendent, Government Press, 1942.

Scott, James C. *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland*

Southeast Asia. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009.

Skocpol, Theda. *States and Social Revolutions: A Comparative Analysis of*

France, Russia, and China. Cambridge and New York: Cambridge

University Press, 1979.

- Sonnerat, Pierre. *Voyage aux Indes orientales et à la Chine, fait par ordre du Roi, depuis 1774 jusqu'en 1781*. Vol. 2. Paris: Chez l'Auteur, 1782.
- Subrahmanyam, Sanjay. *The Political Economy of Commerce: Southern India, 1500–1650*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990.
- Subrahmanyam, Sanjay. *The Portuguese Empire in Asia, 1500–1700: A Political and Economic History*. 2nd ed. Chichester & Malden, MA: Wiley–Blackwell, 2012.
- Surakiat, Pamaree. "Thai–Burmese Warfare during the Sixteenth Century and the Growth of the First Toungoo Empire." *Journal of the Siam Society* 93 (2005): 69–100.
- Symes, Michael. *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava in the Year 1795*. Vol. 1. Edinburgh: Constable & Co., 1827.
- Tambiah, Stanley Jeyaraja. "The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia." *HAU: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 3, no. 3 (2013): 503–34.
- Ternat, François. "Lettre d'or et canon. Diplomatie française et britannique auprès des cours birmanes pendant la guerre de Sept Ans." In *Une diplomatie des lointains. La France face à la mondialisation des rivalités internationales, XVIIe–XVIIIe siècles*, edited by Éric Schnakenbourg and François Ternat, 335–60. Rennes: Presses universitaires de Rennes, 2020.
- Than Tun. *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598–1885*. Vol. 3. Kyoto: Center for Southeast Asian Studies, 1985.

Watson, Burton, trans. *Han Feizi: Basic Writings*. New York: Columbia

University Press, 2003.

Wolters, O. W. *History, Culture, and Region in Southeast Asian Perspectives*. Rev.

ed. Ithaca, NY: Southeast Asia Program Publications, Cornell University,

1999.

Woodman, Dorothy. *The Making of Burma*. London: Cresset Press, 1962.